

CSI 419 Database Management

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Introduction

Starting a new job can be exciting especially when you finally land the one that matches you. I recently accepted a position as a database administrator for a fabric company owned by a man named Clyde. He is a self made millionaire who often talks about prosperity derived from christian values mainly “ a good days work for a good days wage.” Things were going good for the first couple of weeks. But then one morning Clyde brought me into his office and he asked me to create a database that holds employee data. According to him they have been gathering information such as how many keystrokes people have, how long they spend on the phone with clients and even reading their work emails to look for private correspondence. He wants me to do this so he can find out who isn't providing him with “a good day's work.” At first I wasn't sure if I wanted to do this. But I had just started the job so I felt like I didn't have any other choice. After leaving his office I started asking myself “ is this even legal?”. This essay is going to talk about the appropriateness of surveillance and its ethicality from a professional and christian perspective. I'll conclude with a suggestion that, in my opinion, would enable Clyde to gauge productivity without infringing on people's privacy.

Legality

In today's setting employee monitoring has become common in most workplaces. For example, I work for an IT company and they recently just started to see how many problems we fix throughout the day or how much of the software we are creating and think of that nature. Many work places tend to monitor the usage of phones, emails and computer usage. Employers may monitor electronic communications on company owned system instead of using the work phone for stuff that actually matter and not just to talk to your friend or just to get goofing

around. This is the whole purpose of the Communication privacy act of 1986. This implies that since Clyde owns the corporate computer that they have every legal right to monitor their staff member to make sure they are really doing their work during the day and are not just chilling while on the job. But there has to be some kind of limit to all of them because you don't want to invade someone else's privacy over wanting to monitor them during the work day. That's why certain states mandate that businesses must inform workers if they are going to be watched or monitored online throughout the day. Although there isn't really a particular statute prohibiting this in South Carolina there could be a failing to give notice of the monitoring and this could lead to legal problems if workers believe their privacy is being invaded. Like for instance sending personal messages to a corporate computer break and having it reported might be considered going too far. That is why it is very important to tell your team or the person you are monitoring that they are going to be watched so that way we won't be caught in a battle trying to fight and prove that we weren't invading their privacy. Additionally it became Clyde's duty to safeguard this type of data once he began gathering it. Since I will be the one creating the database we might both be held responsible if the data is abused or if it gets leaked out to the other employees. Companies who are going to be collecting this type of data from other employees must ensure that it is protected and is utilized exclusively for authorized business objectives according to Skadden(2022). Therefore Clyde's surveillance strategy is most likely lawful as long as it is limited to corporate devices and employees are made aware of it. However something isn't always right just because it is legal which is where ethics come in. Always want to let your employer know they are being monitored just so there isn't any drama in the work place.

Ethical Analysis

When it comes to monitoring, we have to look at the real issue. The real issue here isn't just about what the law says but it's about the trust and respect between the employer and their workers. For reasons like productivity it could make sense to keep an eye on things like how long employees spend on the phone or how many calls they take but it goes to far when you are literally micromanaging them like looking at every mouse click, email scan or how long they can go without moving the mouse on the computer that is when it goes to far. That type of behavior gives off the impression that management has little faith in its own employees and they don't trust them to do their own work. And trust and believe when trust is lost in a work place it is very difficult to regain it again because what to make them think that you wouldn't do it again. I believe that it is not only Clyde's ethical dilemma but also mine. I have a direct say in how much data is unitized if I design and construct the database that gathers all of the data from employees throughout the day. Another thing is I will still be held accountable for developing a system that may breach people's privacy even if I was only following orders from my boss. For instance I am assisting in making the surveillance achievable. I wouldn't be comfortable with it. I believe it is my responsibility as a professional to stand up and propose a more equitable method of measuring performance of others that only concentrates on actual job outcomes rather than observing people's every move.

Christian Worldview

Clyde claims that he founded his company on christian principles and dont get me wrong he is correct that the bible does emphasize hard work. "If anyone will not work, neither shall eat" as stated in Thessalonians 3:10. Therefore the phrase "good day's work for a good day's wage" is appropriate. However the bible also discusses treating others fairly, honestly and respectfully. "Masters treat your bondservants justly and fairly, knowing that you also have a Master in

heaven” Says Colossians 4:1. This implies that managers like Clyde ought to treat their workers fairly. It doesn't feel fair to observe every action made by employees without their awareness. It betrays a lack of respect and trust. Also Jesus said “Do unto others as you would have them do unto you” in Matthew 7:12. Would Clyde want someone to read his emails and log every word if he were one of the employees? Most likely not. Even in business Christians are expected to behave with compassion, love, and honesty. Don't get me wrong there is nothing wrong with wanting employees to be productive, that is fine but how it's done is important. It is unethical to use technology to surreptitiously observe people. Instead of treating workers as human beings created in God's image it treats them like machines. Clyde should lead with honesty and trust rather than fear and surveillance if he truly wants to operate his business according to the Christian values.

Professional Computing Worldview

As a computer professional we are expected to follow ethical standards too. A code of ethics published by the Association for Computing Machinery provides guidelines for such circumstances. Avoiding damage, respecting privacy and being truthful and fair are the key criteria that apply. According to the ACM code the computer workers must “use personal data only for legitimate ends” and “collect and retain only a minimum amount of personal information necessary.” This implies that I shouldn't create a database that is larger than what is required to complete the task. I would be violating the professional ethic if I contributed to the creation of something that may harm employees or breach their privacy. Additionally according to the ACM code experts must “ensure that systems are robustly and useably secure”. So I have an obligation to ensure that this data is properly protected if Clyde persists in gathering it. It would be a grave ethical transgression on my behalf if I were to develop a system that disclosed private

information. Clyde's request placed me in a very challenging situation from a professional standpoint. I have a duty to respect the people and their privacy but I also want to perform my job because I just recently got it and don't want to be fired from it. Limiting what we gather, perhaps concentrating on performance metrics like call time or completed tasks rather than documenting every action taken by the employees, would be a reasonable strategy. That would still provide Clyde with the information he is looking for without voting against morality.

Conclusion

Fairness, integrity, and respect should direct our behavior, according to both the Christian and professional computing perspectives. Although Clyde's surveillance strategy may be lawful, it violates privacy and undermines confidence, making it unethical in its current form. Only when monitoring is clear, restricted, and concentrated on actual business demands may it take place. I advise Clyde to be transparent with staff members, get just the information that is required, and safeguard it appropriately. Living by the maxim "a good day's work for a good day's wage" entails treating employees with the same decency that he demands of them. Trust, not monitoring, is the foundation of true ethics in the workplace.

References

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